1. Core Concept & Vision

Project Chimera is a mobile-first, "Rogue-like Tactical RPG." It fuses the strategic, grid-based combat of a tactics game with the session-by-session progression and random upgrades of a rogue-like, presented with a classic JRPG battle aesthetic.

- **Player Fantasy:** You are a commander adapting to a constantly changing battlefield. Victory depends on making smart choices with the random cards you are dealt, building a uniquely powerful army in every single match. The player is a master tactician, whose foresight and planning are the keys to victory.
- **Aesthetic:** In-game assets will use the Aekashics **pixel art style** for a nostalgic feel. This retro in-game aesthetic will be contrasted with a clean, minimalist, and modern UI to ensure clarity and ease of use on mobile devices.
- Platform: Mobile (iOS/Android), designed as a mobile-first title.
- **Session Time:** 5-10 minute matches, designed for high replayability and accessibility during short breaks.

2. The Core Gameplay Loop

This is the fundamental, repeatable sequence of actions that defines the player experience.

1. **Battle Start:** The player enters the battlefield with their chosen Hero. On the right is their **4x5 deployment grid**. On the left is a formation of **stationary enemy monsters**.
2. **Resource & Card Flow:**
    - **Aether** (primary resource for summoning) generates automatically.
    - The player is dealt an initial "hand" of **Summon Cards** from their pre-selected deck of 8 Guardians.
3. **The Core Choice (Spend Aether):**
    - **SUMMON:** Drag a **Summon Card** from the hand to a grid tile to deploy a unit. This is the primary way to build your board presence.
    - **USE ABILITY:** Activate your Hero's powerful global abilities, which have long cooldowns.
4. **Combat & EXP Gain:**
    - Your units automatically attack the stationary enemies. Each enemy has clear attack patterns and timers.
    - Defeating enemies grants **EXP**, a secondary resource used exclusively for in-match upgrades.
5. **Level Up & Adapt (The Rogue-like Moment):**
    - After clearing an enemy wave or at set intervals, the game pauses, presenting the player with a choice of **3 random Skill Cards.**

    - These cards can be **new Summons** (Common or a rare Elite) to add to your army, or **Skill Upgrades** for units you already have on the field.
6. **The Upgrade Choice (Spend EXP):**
    - The player spends their accumulated **EXP** to purchase one of the three offered Skill Cards. This choice is the core of the rogue-like strategy.
7. **Win/Lose:**
    - **Win:** Defeat the final Boss wave.
    - **Lose:** Your Crystal's HP reaches zero.

3. Key Systems to Build (MVP)

a. The Battlefield & UI

- **Player Grid (Right Side):** A clearly defined 4x5 grid for unit placement.
- **Enemy Field (Left Side):** An open area where stationary enemy formations appear. Each enemy needs a visible health bar and an attack/cast bar.
- **The Crystal (Right, behind grid):** The player's base HP, representing the Hero's life force.
- **Player UI (Bottom Bar):**
    - Aether and EXP counters.
    - The "hand" of summonable unit cards.
    - Large, easily tappable buttons for the Hero's active abilities.
    - A clear pop-up modal for the "Level Up & Adapt" card choice screen.

b. The Rogue-like Progression System

- Master Card Pool: A developer-controlled list of all possible cards in the game. This includes all Summon cards (Common and Elite) and all multi-level Skill Upgrade cards for every unit.
- **The Draw Mechanic:** When a "Level Up & Adapt" moment occurs, the system randomly draws 3 cards from the master pool. Rarity is weighted so that Common Skill Upgrades are frequent, new Common Summons are less frequent, and Elite Summons are rare and exciting events.
- Unit & Skill Tiers: The specific multi-level upgrade paths for all Heroes, Elite Summons, and Common Summons are detailed in the supplementary V1 Asset & Upgrade Plan document.

c. Playable Units (The Player's Army)

For the MVP, units are divided into three distinct categories, all drawn from the same card pool during gameplay.

1. **Playable Heroes:** The player chooses one to lead them into battle (e.g., Stan, Apolonia). Their starting skills are automatically available at Level 1. Heroes

provide powerful active abilities and passive army-wide buffs.

2. **Elite Summons:** Rare, powerful units that can be found in the card draw. They have 3 Tiers of upgradable skills, just like Heroes (e.g., Knight, Scythe Master, Samurai).
3. **Common Summons:** The most frequent cards. These are lower-cost, utility-focused creatures with 2 Tiers of upgradable skills. They are essential for filling out the player's board (e.g., Mossback Tortoise, Grave Spinner, Goblin Sapper).

d. Enemies

Enemies are designed as tactical puzzles to challenge different aspects of the player's formation.

- **Minions:** Numerous units that test the player's AoE capabilities (e.g., Goblins).
- **Elites:** Specialized units requiring specific counters (e.g., an Armored Knight resistant to physical damage, or a healer Shaman that must be prioritized).
- **Boss:** A single, powerful unit with unique, telegraphed attacks that require precise positioning and damage output to defeat.

4. Game Modes & Player Flow

The user journey from app launch to gameplay must be fast and intuitive.

1. Sign-In Screen: Simple options: "Play as Guest" or "Sign In."
2. Main Menu:
    - PLAY (Portal): The primary button, leading directly to the Hero selection screen and then into a match.
    - VANGUARDS (Collection): A gallery to view all possible Heroes, Summons, and their skill trees (read-only).
    - STORY MODE (Locked): Placeholder for a future co-op campaign designed as an extended, engaging tutorial.
    - PVP MODE (Locked): Placeholder for a future competitive mode.
3. Hero Select: Player chooses their Hero for the upcoming match.
4. Deck Management: Player ensures their "deck" of 8 preferred Common and Elite summons is set. Initially, a default starter deck is provided.

5. Future-Proofing (Post-MVP)

These concepts are critical for long-term success but are not required for the initial prototype.

- Story Mode: A 1-4 player co-op campaign that introduces new mechanics, units, and enemies over time, serving as an engaging tutorial.
- PVP Mode: A competitive 1v1 or 2v2 mode where players also spend resources to

send "Mercenary" units to their opponent's board, creating a dynamic offense/defense resource battle.

- Meta-Progression: A long-term system where players earn currency and "shards" from chests to permanently level up their Guardians outside of matches, increasing their base stats. This is a core retention driver.
- Live-Ops & Esports: A commitment to regular balance patches, the introduction of new Guardians to evolve the meta, and a focus on visual clarity to build a healthy, competitive, and watchable game.